

AFRICA, NORTHWEST

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MOROCCO, ALGERIA, TUNISIA, and Libya, plus the disputed territory of Western Sahara, make up the northwest corner of Africa. The region has been dominated by Arabs and their religion, Islam, for more than 1,300 years. Algeria and Libya are huge countries, but much of the land is desert. However, they and Tunisia have abundant reserves of oil and natural gas. Farming, made possible by irrigation projects, is still important to the region. Many people lead nomadic lives roaming the land with their herds of animals.

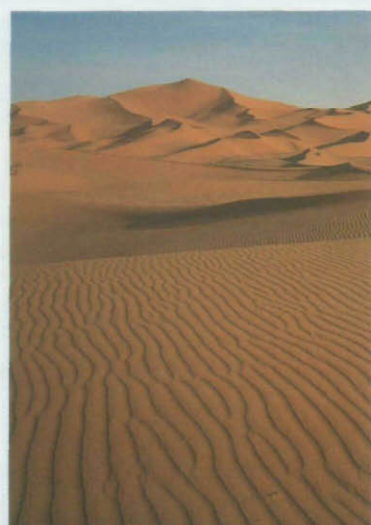
Physical features

Along the Mediterranean and Atlantic coasts is a fertile strip where most of the people live. The Atlas Mountain chain runs across Morocco and continues as rolling hills in Algeria and Tunisia. The rest of the land is desert, broken by oases and bleak mountain ranges.



Regional climate

Along most of the coast and on high ground, summers are hot and dry and winters are warm and wet. Daytime desert temperatures average about 38°C (100°F); at night they are low. Desert rainfall may be as little as 2.5 cm (1 in) a year, and irregular.



Sahara

The Sahara Desert covers about 9,065,000 sq km (3,263,400 sq miles). Only about one-fifth is sand. The rest includes vast, flat expanses of barren rock and gravel and mountains such as Algeria's Ahaggar range, peaking at 2,918 m (9,573 ft). Crops are grown in 90 large oases.

Berbers

The original people of Northwest Africa are the Berbers. Today, about 15,000,000 Berbers still live in the mountains and deserts of the region. Most are Muslim, but retain their own language and dialects. The Tuatag are a group of nomadic Berber herders who roam the North African desert.



Berber man and child



Mediterranean coast

Once occupied by the Phoenicians, Greeks, and Romans, northwest Africa's Mediterranean coast has many ancient ruins that are particularly popular with tourists in Morocco, Algeria, and Tunisia. Most people live on the coastal plain, which has fertile land and a warm climate.

Atlas Mountains

The Atlas Mountains consist of several chains of mountains that stretch 2,410 km (1,500 miles) from the Atlantic coast of Morocco to Cape Bon in eastern Tunisia. The highest peak is Djebel Toubkal at 4,167 m (13,665 ft), which lies in the High Atlas range in southern Morocco.